ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Biotechnology English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For biotech scientists, translational researchers, assay-development teams, platform teams, program managers, alliance managers, business-development staff, and biotech executives.

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.

2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.

3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.

4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.

5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Platform claims

A scientist and program lead discuss an investor slide.

Roles: Platform scientist / Program lead

Platform scientist: The slide says our platform works across all tumor types. Our data cover two cell lines.

Program lead: Then the claim exceeds the evidence. What can we say precisely?

Platform scientist: We observed the effect in these models under the tested conditions. Broader applicability remains a hypothesis.

Program lead: Keep that distinction in the headline, not only in a footnote.

Platform scientist: I'll add the model names, controls, and replicate information.

Program lead: Good. The next milestone should test generalizability rather than present it as established.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Then the claim exceeds the evidence. What can we say precisely?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Assay variability

Two scientists troubleshoot inconsistent assay results.

Roles: Assay scientist / Laboratory lead

Assay scientist: The coefficient of variation increased in this week's runs. The positive control also shifted.

Laboratory lead: Was there a reagent lot change or a change in instrument settings?

Assay scientist: A new antibody lot, but the settings are unchanged in the run records.

Laboratory lead: Let's compare lot performance and verify the controls before pooling the results.

Assay scientist: I'll retain the raw data and list any deviations from the assay procedure.

Laboratory lead: We'll agree on the investigation and repeat criteria before generating replacement data.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Was there a reagent lot change or a change in instrument settings?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Biomarker interpretation

A translational team reviews an exploratory result.

Roles: Translational scientist / Biostatistician

Translational scientist: Biomarker-positive samples show a stronger response. Can we call it predictive?

Biostatistician: Not from this comparison alone. We need to consider design, sample size, and how the analysis was specified.

Translational scientist: So this is an exploratory association that needs further evaluation?

Biostatistician: Yes. Show the uncertainty and avoid implying clinical utility has been demonstrated.

Translational scientist: I'll revise the slide and state which samples were included.

Biostatistician: I'll check the analysis description and identify what a confirmatory study would need to address.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Biomarker-positive samples show a stronger response. Can we call it predictive?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Preclinical package review

A program team reviews a gap in study documentation.

Roles: Study director / Program manager

Study director: The summary is ready, but the exposure data haven't completed quality review.

Program manager: Can we include the draft figures in the partner package?

Study director: Only if their provisional status and permitted use are clear under our review process.

Program manager: The partner is asking whether the dose-response relationship is established.

Study director: We shouldn't imply that before the relevant data and interpretation are reviewed.

Program manager: I'll communicate the package status and propose a follow-up once the outstanding review is complete.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can we include the draft figures in the partner package?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Scale-up comparability

A process team discusses a change in production scale.

Roles: Process development scientist / Analytical lead

Process development scientist: Yield increased at the larger scale, but the impurity profile shifted.

Analytical lead: Higher yield doesn't establish comparability. Which attributes moved, and by how much?

Process development scientist: Two peaks increased. Their identities are still being investigated.

Analytical lead: Preserve the original chromatograms and compare analytical methods, sampling records, and process conditions for both scales.

Process development scientist: I'll assemble the batch history and proposed investigation questions.

Analytical lead: We'll review the quality attributes before recommending further use of the material.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Higher yield doesn't establish comparability. Which attributes moved, and by how much?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Collaboration and IP

A scientist prepares to share a protocol with a prospective partner.

Roles: Research scientist / Alliance manager

Research scientist: The partner wants our complete assay protocol before the collaboration agreement is signed.

Alliance manager: Check the confidentiality terms and permitted disclosure with the appropriate legal and IP reviewers first.

Research scientist: Could we share a high-level methods summary for their feasibility assessment?

Alliance manager: Possibly. Define exactly what they need and let the reviewers approve the scope.

Research scientist: I'll separate public information from unpublished method details.

Alliance manager: I'll coordinate the review and record what is approved for the exchange.

Notice the professional language

IP - Intellectual property: legally recognized rights in certain creations, inventions, and identifying marks.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Board milestone update

A biotech team explains a delayed program milestone.

Roles: Program manager / Research director

Program manager: The lead-selection milestone has moved. Is the delay technical or simply scheduling?

Research director: Both. The assay transfer took longer, and two candidates need additional characterization.

Program manager: Which work changes the decision, and which work can proceed in parallel?

Research director: Characterization informs selection. Documentation can continue while those results are pending.

Program manager: I'll show the decision dependency, current spend, and revised planning assumptions.

Research director: Keep the date conditional until we confirm the remaining experiment schedule and review requirements.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The lead-selection milestone has moved. Is the delay technical or simply scheduling?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Partner diligence

A business-development lead clarifies a partner's data request.

Roles: Business development lead / Scientific lead

Business development lead: The partner asks for all reproducibility data. Which datasets address that question?

Scientific lead: Independent runs, control performance, method versions, and the results that didn't reproduce.

Business development lead: Including negative results may prompt difficult questions.

Scientific lead: They are necessary context. A selected subset could misrepresent the platform's current performance.

Business development lead: I'll arrange a controlled data-room review with the approved disclosure scope.

Scientific lead: I'll prepare a clear explanation of the limitations and the experiments underway to address them.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The partner asks for all reproducibility data. Which datasets address that question?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Platform Technology and Scientific Thesis

SHARED CASE

A platform produces a promising signal in one experimental system. An investor slide says it will work across several diseases.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The finding is promising in this experimental system. We have not established its relevance across diseases. I'll distinguish the current evidence from the broader platform hypothesis.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Assay Development and Reproducibility

SHARED CASE

An assay gives consistent results within one run but different results across three days. A colleague calls it fully reproducible.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

Within-run consistency and performance across days are different questions. Let's report both and investigate the between-day variation before describing the assay as reproducible under those conditions.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Biomarkers and Translational Strategy

SHARED CASE

A team calls a biomarker "validated" without specifying whether it means analytical performance or clinical usefulness.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What kind of validation do you mean here? Could we distinguish the assay's analytical performance from evidence about the biomarker's clinical use? The slide needs to state which claim the data support.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Preclinical Data Packages

SHARED CASE

An animal study shows an effect at one tested exposure. A summary describes the result as proof of human benefit.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The result describes the tested animal model and exposure. It does not establish human benefit. I'll state the finding and the limits on translating it to a clinical setting.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

CMC and Scale-Up in Biotech

SHARED CASE

A process transfer achieved the expected yield in two small runs. Performance at a larger scale remains untested.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The two small runs met the expected yield. Larger-scale performance is still untested. I'll present scale-up as an open question and identify the next planned evidence point.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

IP, Freedom to Operate, and Collaboration

SHARED CASE

Two partners want to exchange materials. The draft arrangement leaves publication and permitted-use questions unresolved.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could the responsible teams confirm the permitted uses and publication terms before the exchange? I'll summarize the scientific purpose and the unresolved questions for review.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Investor and Board Updates

SHARED CASE

A project update lists completed experiments but does not connect them to the next funding milestone.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll group the results around the milestone question: what have we learned, what remains uncertain, and what evidence is needed next? That will make the funding discussion easier to follow.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Partnering and Business Development

SHARED CASE

A potential partner requests exclusive rights before the scope of the collaboration is defined.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that ... .

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

We can discuss exclusivity alongside the proposed scope, responsibilities, and milestones. Could we first clarify which activities and rights you have in mind so the appropriate teams can evaluate the request?

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.